

steering AHEAD

✱ **Mujeeb Khan, 33**

Project To adapt cars and make the physically-disabled mobile

Can-do Icon Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, who set the economy free and gave a fillip to entrepreneurship.

Nearly **600** polio cases were registered in India last year

"I wanted to drive like my father," says Mujeeb Khan, who hasn't been able to walk since the age of two because of polio. In a country where the physically-disabled are not provided with proper facilities, Khan, a mechanic, decided to take matters into his own hands. It all started some years ago, when his father, a laboratory helper in Rajasthan

University in Jaipur, bought an old Maruti van. Khan, who has been pottering around with mechanical things since childhood, would wait till his father left for work and then make changes to the car. He would restore it to its original shape before his father returned as he feared being caught. After testing it, he challenged his family to test-drive it to Delhi and back. During the drive, he covered 270 km in just four hours. When he took a break at a dhaba, a family travelling from Uttar Pradesh was taken aback when he got out of the vehicle and took out his crutches. "The entire family shook hands with me," he recalls with pride.

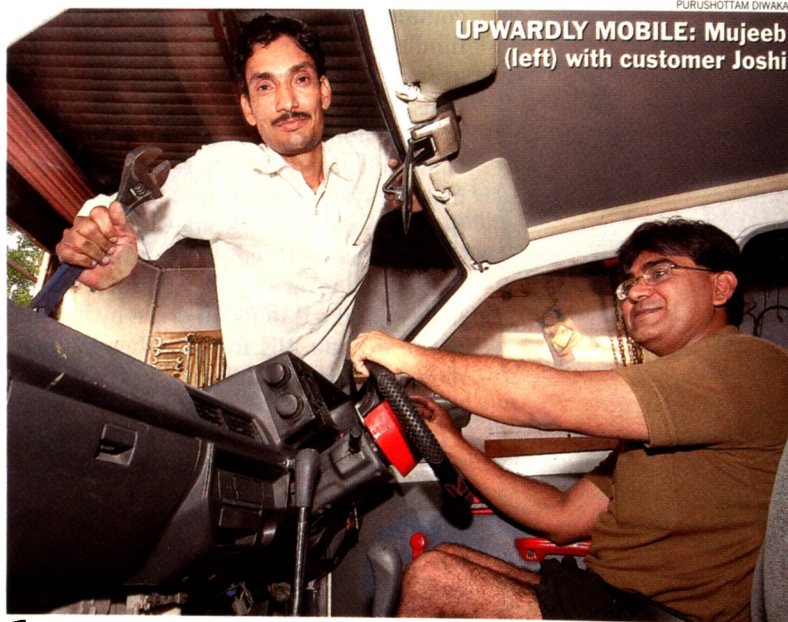
In the initial changes he made to his Maruti van, he shifted the original brake cylinder, but the modified version was based solely on hand functions. He has now made a model that allows the use of either hands or feet or both. Buyers, who have heard of him through the media, frequent him from different cities in the state, due to which he has modified 250 cars so far. He charges between Rs 10,000-15,000 for small cars like the lower-end models of Maruti and Alto and Rs 20,000 for bigger cars, plus a labour fee of Rs 2,000.

Mahendra Joshi, an employee at the regional passport office, is a permanent customer. A polio victim since the age of three, Joshi, 40, now drives a modified 1984 Maruti 800. Previously, he drove a modified three-wheel version of an LML scooter for many years till he lost balance one day and injured himself. "I was reluctant to drive the modified car Mujeeb has designed," he says. But within two days, he was driving comfortably to work, a 14-km distance from home. "It is convenient and well-balanced," he says, and at Rs 65,000, "it's a good bargain".

Ramphul Gurjar, 29, a property dealer, bought a Maruti 800 to get it adapted in 2007 and liked it so much that within six months he got his new Logan modified by Khan. He too was afflicted by polio at the age of three. He says driving a bigger car impresses his clients and he has travelled 10,000 km in a-month-and-a-half.

Khan says, "A tricycle is associated with the physically-challenged, whereas a car makes us feel like regular mobile persons. His invention is now breaking barriers for the physically-disabled. Sometimes, he gets requests from able-bodied persons who drive long-distances to modify a car so it can be used with the hands and feet. From the margins, truly to the mainstream.

by Rohit Parihar



UPWARDLY MOBILE: Mujeeb (left) with customer Joshi

"If people see us driving, they think we have no disability and friends who used to offer lifts, ask for one now."

MUJEEB KHAN, Mechanic